

# Coby L. Kassner

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Student researcher with broad interests in technical AI safety and mechanistic interpretability.

## Experience

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### Research Fellow

February–May 2025

Supervised Program for Alignment Research ( [SPAR](#) )

- Researched neural networks that are [inherently interpretable](#), mentored by Dr. Ronak Mehta
- Measured viability and interpretability of simplex-constrained MLP and Transformer variants

### Student Researcher

2024–Present

Julia Student Research Group

- Headed [project to extract synthetic training data](#) from a fine-tuned Llama 3.1 8B instance
- Utilized contrastive activation addition to steer model outputs towards memorized examples
- Achieved ~2x baseline success rate, placing 7th in the LLM Privacy Challenge, Red Team, at NeurIPS 2024

### Student Researcher

Summer 2024

Association of Students for Research in Artificial Intelligence

- Led project in natural language processing to understand dis/misinformation in the context of LLMs
- Benchmarked LLM fact-checking performance across 5 languages and several prompting techniques
- Co-first author [publication](#) in NLP4PI workshop at EMNLP 2024

### Staff Team

2023–2024

International Research Olympiad ( [IRO](#) )

- Directed program to start over 320 research clubs in secondary schools across 40 countries and 6 continents
- Collaborated with leadership team to coordinate over 50 student volunteers, negotiate over \$15,000 in sponsorships to fund research clubs, and staff and organize in-person finals event in Cambridge, MA

## Technical Skills

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**Research:** LLM fine-tuning and inference, small-model training (GPT-2), custom transformer variants, activation steering, PINNs/PINOs, neuroevolution (NEAT, Hyper-NEAT, CPPNs)

**Libraries:** Transformers (HuggingFace), PyTorch, JAX, Scikit-Learn, Pandas, NumPy, Transformer Lens, APIs

**Languages:** Python (6 years), C++ (3 years)

## Education

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### Statistics and Data Science, B.S.

2025–2029

Yale College

*Activities:* Effective Altruism (Board Member, Intro Fellowship Manager), AI Alignment, Undergrad Math Society

*Coursework:* Trustworthy Deep Learning

### Computer Science, A.S. and Mathematics, A.S.

2021–2025

Arapahoe Community College (concurrent enrollment)

*Coursework:* Linear Algebra, Calculus III, CS (C++; Data Structures, Algorithms, OOP), Computer Architecture

### High School Diploma

2021–2025

Colorado Early Colleges Douglas County North

Class rank: 4/209